

Security Watch

RealPlayer and Rhapsody 3

The Problem

Security holes in RealNetworks' media player software that could put PCs at risk of attack have been reported by security experts at the French Security Incident Response Team. These problems have been labelled 'critical'. The problems are prevalent in current and some older releases of RealPlayer, and they affect different versions of Windows as well as Mac OS and Linux, RealNetworks said. In addition, one of the newly patched bugs is also found in Rhapsody 3, the software used in RealNetworks' music service.

The Damages

Four vulnerabilities in RealPlayer have been discovered, the most serious of which could allow an intruder to gain control of a computer. Three of the four flaws could be exploited using a malicious media file. Specially crafted RealMedia and AVI files could allow an attacker to take over a user's computer, while a malicious MP3 file could be used to overwrite local files or execute ActiveX controls, the report said.

To take advantage of the fourth flaw, a hacker would need to build a malicious Web site. However, the attack would require the user to be running earlier versions of Internet Explorer with standard settings.

Precautions

RealNetworks has put up an updated version of the player on the Web, at www.real.com/player. This has plugged the security holes found in the earlier version.



In addition to this permission, the Justice Department of the United States is asking the airlines to maintain strict control over their broadband links. This also includes the ability to automatically identify every user by his or her name and seat number, remotely cut off access, cut off all passengers' access without affecting the flight crew's access, or re-direct communications to and from the aircraft in the event of a crisis.

Officials also expressed concern that terrorists might use in-flight broadband to remotely trigger a bomb hidden on a plane. They asked the concerned authorities to keep such services from being accessible from the cargo hull of an aircraft.

Despite all safety concerns, though, companies and airlines are

generally bullish on airborne broadband. Security agencies are also lauding its potential to enhance communications between the air and the ground during a crisis.

WIRELESS VOIP

Voice Over Wireless Internet Coming Soon

You cut long-distance phone call costs using VoIP, but then you are bound to the computer. Not anymore. VoIP provider Skype and Boingo Wireless, a wireless hotspot operator, have unveiled a new initiative to combine technologies offered by both companies.

HOT Podcasting

The RSS equivalent of audio distribution; audio files can be automatically downloaded and listened to at your convenience. Podcasting is helping radio stations across Europe and the US create customised radio shows.

NOT Audio Streaming

The Internet-dependent way of listening to music or radio is passé. Audio breaks, and there is lag and interruptions, too! The quality is not so great either, and compatibility with media players remains an issue.

VoIP subscribers use a wired phone line to place their call. However, many Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) service providers see an opportunity to create wireless versions of their services using Wi-Fi. Introducing the appropriate VoIP service and technology could, in effect, convert Wi-Fi hotspots into giant phone booths.

Although this is Skype's first venture with Boingo, the hotspot aggregator has already entered the VoIP arena. Earlier this year, New Jersey-based Vonage, the world's largest commercial VoIP operator, and Boingo Wireless, agreed to co-market each other's services. Boingo said it is working with handset makers to integrate its software into Wi-Fi-ready phones.

One Silly Question Is your computer male or female?



"Male because it is made by a male"

Aghariya M Husen, Mumbai



"Female! Everybody wants to know her vital stats (configuration)"

Yogesh Sharma, Baroda



"Female! She is intelligent and very sleek"

Kinjal Mehta, Mumbai



"Male! It needs to be turned on all the time..."

Gaurav Jain, Bangalore



"Female! Because I can never figure out what went wrong!"

Rajiv Shah, Mumbai